

Nothing Phone 4a

Flair and finesse, now with more focus

I have used every Nothing device, starting from the Phone 1 to the Phone 3a Lite, and I will admit that I do quite like what the company is doing, especially in terms of innovations, as well as what works for them. Of course, what really always catches me is their design. This time as well, the company has brought something new to their design called 'Glyph Bar'. But this time, the Nothing Phone 4a, succeeding the Phone 3a, comes in a slightly different position. I say this because things are a bit more complicated, as there is a price jump from the Nothing Phone 3a. And at this price point, the expectations are naturally higher. At around Rs 30,000, users are not just looking for something that looks different, but also expect a phone that performs well across the board. So does the Nothing Phone 4a deliver enough for its price? Let's find out.

DESIGN AND BUILD

Design has always been the main characteristic of Nothing phones, and the Phone 4a continues that legacy. The transparent back panel remains the centrepiece where you can see the components and visible screws. Nothing (no pun intended) out of the ordinary for Nothing, but I will say that the Phone 4a gives the look that still feels unique in this crowded smartphone market.

That said, the back panel now feels more minimal. Instead of the full Glyph light, Nothing has introduced a Glyph Bar on the right side of the camera module. This strip contains 63 mini-LEDs arranged across seven segments. This strip can be customised within the settings, allowing users to adjust bright-

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ness levels. One of the more satisfying touches is the way the LEDs react when you adjust the volume.

Another small detail is the red square indicator in the Glyph Bar, which lights up when recording begins, just like its bigger sibling, the Nothing Phone 3.

The back has a glossy finish, which looks good but tends to attract fingerprints. You can avoid smudges by using the back cover, which comes in the box.

From a build perspective, the Phone 4a feels solid in hand. The frame is sturdy, and the button placement has been changed as well. The volume rocker now sits on the right side, making it easier to reach in everyday use. The Essential Key has also moved to the left side, because earlier in Nothing Phone 3a, users had complaints about it getting accidentally pressed. It's fixed.

The front of the Phone 4a is protected by the Gorilla Glass 7i and the

device is certified with an IP64 rating for dust and water resistance.

Overall, the Nothing Phone 4a remains one of the most eye-catching phones in its segment. Whether this design appeals to you is subjective, but there is no denying that Nothing has built out a clear identity for itself.

DISPLAY

The Nothing Phone 4a features a 6.78-inch 1.5K LTPS AMOLED display with a 120Hz refresh rate that can drop to 30Hz. In daily use, the display feels smooth and responsive. Partly the reason behind the smoothness is Nothing OS 4.1 atop Android 16. The company promises 3 years of main OS updates paired with 6 years of security patches. But, more on the software in a later section. For now, when it comes to this phone's display, I used it for all kinds of stuff. Chrome, video-calls, emails, Instagram and Twitter, switched between apps, and all felt fluid. Of course, along with the high-refresh rate screen, Nothing OS animations are also very smooth and polished.

Now, to test the display, I took the Phone 4a to our Digit Test Labs, where the display performed well. In the Calman Colour Test, the panel recorded an average Delta E of 2.4, which is okay. In the Colour Gamut test, the display achieved 99.9% coverage. Brightness is another strong point. In our testing, the panel reached 2,640 nits of peak brightness, making it easy to use under direct sunlight.

While these were the simulated tests, I am also happy to report that in real-world use, watching content, be it YouTube videos or OTT, on the panel is an enjoyable experience. The AMOLED display delivers deep blacks, the contrast is strong, and the overall clarity is excellent. I watched Taskaree on Netflix, and I enjoyed watching that series on this display. Putting it there once again, in everyday usage, the Phone 4a's display feels sharp, bright and colourful.